



I CAN'T SEEM TO STOP SINGING WHEREVER I AM

THE SOUND OF MUSIC / 1965

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Musical

DIRECTOR
Robert Wise

WRITERS
Ernest Lehman (screenplay); Maria von Trapp (book); George Hurdalek, Howard Lindsay, Russel Crouse (stage musical)

STARS
Julie Andrews, Christopher Plummer, Eleanor Parker

BEFORE
1956 Ruth Leuwerik stars in *The Trapp Family*, a German adaptation of von Trapp's book.

1959 *The Sound of Music* opens on Broadway, composed by Richard Rodgers with lyrics by Oscar Hammerstein II.

AFTER
1972 The musical *Cabaret* is set in Berlin at the time of the Nazis' rise to power.

Today, screenings of *The Sound of Music* are often billed as sing-alongs, at which audiences who know every lyric enjoy a sense of shared nostalgia for the songs. Yet behind the fun there is a significant movie.

The story of a misfit postulant, Maria (Julie Andrews), who leaves her abbey to become governess to the seven unruly children of a stern widower, Captain Georg von Trapp (Christopher Plummer), unfolds in the bucolic, chocolate-box setting of the Austrian Alps. Maria's good humor and musical inventiveness win over the children

and, gradually, the captain's heart. Set in 1938, and based on a true story, the movie continues to resonate, perhaps because it represents values that were almost extinguished in one of Europe's darkest periods.

Vulnerable innocence

The movie's first half focuses on Maria's acceptance into the von Trapp family and the dilemma she faces when the captain begins to fall in love with her, despite his engagement to an aristocratic socialite, Baroness Schraeder (Eleanor Parker). Distraught at



Robert Wise Director

Born in 1914 in Winchester, IN, Robert Wise was 19 when he got a job as a sound and music editor at RKO radio pictures, and he eventually became Orson Welles's editor on movies such as *Citizen Kane* (pp.66–71). Wise's first directing job was on *The Curse of the Cat People* (1944), and he went on to direct many notable B movies such as *The Day the Earth Stood*

Still (1951) and *The Haunting* (1963). Later in life he worked on musicals, most famously making *West Side Story* and *The Sound of Music*. Wise died at 91 in 2005.

Key movies

1945 *The Body Snatcher*
1951 *The Day the Earth Stood Still*
1961 *West Side Story*
1965 *The Sound of Music*